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Sheryl Bailey

Guitarist Sheryl Bailey transitioned from heavy metal to jazz after hearing Wes Montgomery on the radio. She fashioned a career in New York, frequently collaborating with Gary Versace, Ian Froman, and Harvie S. She is on the faculty at Berklee College of Music.

Sheryl was interviewed via Zoom on July 24, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Sheryl Bailey with me today, a jazz guitarist and educator. And in an article in *Vintage Guitar* magazine you were described as "Guitar goddess of modern jazz."

SB: Woo. Wow.

MR: I hope that's on your resume.

SB: Yes. It's definitely on my resume. Who wouldn't put it on their resume?

MR: Did you — I read you had aspirations or you were — I don't want to overstate this, perhaps you wanted to be the guitar goddess of heavy metal?

SB: Yeah, well yeah. When I was a teenager I — well I grew up in a family of professional — actually church organists really. And so we had to study piano and I'm telling you my — wherever she would be in the universe — if my piano teacher knew that I was a professional musician and educator she'd probably just, I don't know, she'd be in shock. Because I was not a great piano student. But — maybe because everybody played at a really high level in my family and I don't know, I was also a little younger, I was rebellious, and I saw the guitar and I just fell in love with the guitar so that was what I wanted to do. And of course guitar to a teenager is rock music. So I played what I guess is now called classic rock and blues originally, you know, I was into Hendrix and Robin Trower and all those kind of players out of that Hendrix school. And then I got into heavy metal, because I was a serious musician and at that time and mind of my teenage mind I was like well those folks are virtuosos so that's the way to go. And then, and I still do, I call on that technique quite a bit in my project with Anat Cohen and the tentet project, you know there's a sequence in there that's all about just using that kind of technique and sound. So I mean I just kind of — I love guitar playing, virtuosic guitar playing in any genre. I'm not picky about that.

MR: Did you have a period where you were playing some fairly technical music in that genre but you had yet to find out — I hesitate to say this because it sounds like an insult almost, but you didn't know what you were doing from a musical standpoint from a chordal

SB: I think so. I mean I think that's in everyone's development for sure. Coming from a family of keyboard players, and I mean I mean harmony was so present in my imagination and musical world so I think that was the draw. I mean some of that actually, some of that neoclassical — they call it neoclassical shred is, they are Bach chord progressions and stuff. But did I know what it was? But that was what drew me to study at Berklee as a kid because I grew up with harmony and then you know that of course was an easy invitation into jazz and standards that I said I hear that but I don't know what it's called. And I still feel this way and I'm not rah-rah-rah Berklee, even though I'm associated there. But that's what they do great is teach harmonic analysis, which — that was what I wanted to know. Because my ears — I never had perfect pitch, I have really good relative pitch but I said oh there are patterns there. What are those called? But I think that's kind of everybody's evolution in their musicianship at some point.

MR: I'm always fascinated by — guitar players especially who are self-taught, didn't go to music school. For about six years I played in a group that was playing early Yes and Genesis and very complex music. And the guitar players had an easier time learning it than I did. And I had graduated from music school. And their ability to hear and not get hung up about odd measures or forms was positive for them.

SB: Um hum. Yeah I think, I mean I think there's finding that balance between I think as guitar players — well that's always — there's tons of jokes about sight reading guitarists and stuff that we often learn — it's the people's instrument. Someone shows you some chords. Oh here's the chords to a Beatles song. And you just play it. And there's an entry point where it's easy and can sound good easily to a certain degree, and so you can do that for a long time. But you are more oriented towards just your ears, not in an educated way of your ears is where you would study ear training and be able to identify intervals. But you also develop more of an intuitive sense I think you don't have that fear. I mean I know some amazing — and I know you do too — some amazing classical musicians that are terrified, even if they had to improvise on a session for two bars. But you know I mean I can read and I'm a good reader but I always feel if I have to play, if I had to play a Broadway show or something, I'm like sweating bullets, the pressure of like nailing everything in that kind of precision. So I think wherever you come from you have strengths in different areas. I think the thing, the pursuit about developing our musicianship is to make all those areas as strong as possible so you don't have weaknesses. But we all have them, you know?

MR: What do you tell your students, I'm kind of leapfrogging to something I was going to ask later but do your students need to be versatile to make a living in this world today? How do you describe that to them?

SB: Yeah, I mean I think — here's what I think about it. In terms of musicianship, I mean because again, I grew up in a family with professional musicians so I never really thought much about it, but a lot of people were coming — they don't really understand what is this path that you're going out on. And from my point of view growing up, I wanted to get my ears together and my musicianship together. Because I was like if I can hear it I can play it, so if somebody calls me for a gig and also where I can read it, I can — that's all I want to do is just make a living playing the guitar. And I didn't care if it was a country band or — so I feel like that openness to music has got to be number one. And the love of music. You have to love it so passionately for those times when it's really hard. That love has got to be there. So I think — I don't know, you could think of maybe put it maybe more, [inaudible]. You could go out and buy the Powerball lottery ticket and maybe you're going to win, but you could also invest your money and diversify your funds and you'll probably be successful, a lot more successful. Maybe you're not going to be a millionaire but you're going to be more successful.

MR: Have you ever had students that were, you know, they were pretty good but they didn't seem — as you describe — to really love it? And have you felt like you need to tell them either you have to love this so much that you can't do anything else, or maybe you should go and do an other kind of — pursue something else? I mean you can't make people love something.

SB: No you can't. I think that is part of the journey. And in terms of even thinking about on a collegiate level just across the board, that first year of college for almost everybody is exploring and finding yourself. And maybe you're going to go through that and you're going to realize, maybe this isn't for me, this isn't what I thought. I think that's going to be true for — really that first year is the first time you've been away, first time you've been alone, trying to find your identity and maybe you find it. But at the same time the — what we learn, so beyond being on the collegiate level for a profession, a big thing that was important that my mother also taught me is we can put it say music is for everybody but education is for everybody for the longevity of your life. Developing your intelligence and developing your skills is something you use all your life. So even if you come to this — you go through this process and you go hey I'm not going to be a professional musician, the skills that you learn, problem solving, time management, all of this is translatable. And that's why arts education is so important on all levels. Not to make the next, you know, Chick Corea or Keith Jarrett. Do we all have to be thinking about creating virtuosos? We need to be sharing what the discipline and the art form is, and that's for everybody, wherever they want to come into it. And I think that's the thing. Some people will go, "I'm too old to learn an instrument." I'm like, "Somebody told you

MR: Well said. Was there a particular artist and even beyond that a particular LP that put you on the jazz path?

SB: Yeah, well you know I'm from the Pittsburgh area and there was a radio station back when you had way more independent radio stations, WYEP, and they had all kinds of — it was public access radio. And you know I just listened to all kinds of things there. And I turned it on and I heard Sonny Rollins. And then I heard Charlie Parker. And then I heard Wes Montgomery. And then I just was hooked. It was an addiction from there. So then I started — my mother actually — at the time I was playing in a rock band and my grades were terrible. I mean I was playing gigs in bars. I was a teenager. And I said well that's what I'm going to do. And my mother said, "Well you have to study." You know, "You're going to go to school for this." I said, "Okay, okay." So she introduced me to a teacher, his name is John Mayone in Pittsburgh, and so through him he made me recordings of Jimmy Raney, Wes Montgomery, and Herb Ellis. And at that time they were cassette tapes and they were sort of collections of things. And Joe Pass. And actually in Pittsburgh at that time there were a lot of — Joe Pass — I used to see him a lot. I would see Tal Farlow, I saw Herb Ellis. They would come through because of Joe Negri from Mr. Rogers Neighborhood. That was a Pittsburgh community. And through handyman Joe Negri all these great jazz artists and jazz guitarists would come through Pittsburgh. So anyway just that experience, and then it became something that, you know me and my mom would do — go, "Hey, who's playing in town." We saw Ella and we saw Andre Previn, we saw Mel Torme, you know whoever that was — so that was my experience getting into jazz. But the early recordings were those folks you know. Jimmy Raney for sure and Charlie Parker.

MR: Yeah. Did you have to go out and then get a different kind of guitar?

SB: I did. Well I did. I bought a — I had an ES 335, a cherry finish, that I bought. I think it was $600 then which is amazing. But I still have, actually I wish I'd saved it, when we cleaned out my mother's home I found a practice schedule that I had where I was torn between heavy metal and jazz and I had my practice schedule and it was cut in half. Like an hour on this and an hour — that's the way kids think, it's just funny.

MR: Great. Did your mom get to see some of your successes?

SB: Yes she did, absolutely. And I mean I was in the Monk competition and she was able to see that. Yeah. Yeah. She got to see that the music lessons paid off.

MR: Nice. Do you ever find yourself sitting in and you know, just playing some Rolling Stones?

SB: Sure. I love all that stuff. Count me in. I always would say, you know I think it was Ornette said it, it was like there's no such thing as bad music there's bad musicians. You

know what I mean? Like yeah, if some cats are playing and want to play, you know, "Can't Get No Satisfaction" that's going to be grooving.

MR: Here's a quote from Sheryl Bailey: "The blues is such a unifying principle. All great jazz should have blues in it."

SB: Oh. I said that?

MR: You did say that.

SB: Oh good. I agree. I totally concur.

MR: I'm fascinated by the blues and how so many early rock & roll songs were just sped up blues. And do you spend time with, especially your freshman students, playing the blues?

SB: Yeah. And I mean, I mean the blues itself as a song form, the blues it's a great vehicle. If we were here together we could say it's a great thing, "Hey let's play a blues." There's always going to be a blues in a set list or a jam session, right? So it's a great conversation starter, you can think of that. But you know also, the players that I love, Bird and Cannonball Adderley and Hank Mobley and I mean they're all so steeped in the blues. And so through transcribing them, either an actual blues or just in their playing it's so embedded in there that to me that's what's exciting in a good player.

MR: I'd like to talk about your composing for a bit. I've been listening to some of your recent works, "Search for a New Light" and I like the adjectives or your description of chord voicings and you're using the terms dark and bright and drama.

SB: Um hum.

MR: Very interesting.

SB: Ah. Well you know the ancient Greeks were very intelligent people and they — so their three elements of music correspond to three areas. So rhythm is the body, melody is the mind and harmony is the heart. So I always just feel that's the drama and emotion, to me it's harmony. You have a note, you put a feeling or a vibe or if you want to call it a vibe or an emotion, or it could be more of a color if you are more visually oriented. So that's what I feel about in writing, I have a melody and I have a sense of a texture or a vibe or a mood. So if I had a G note, if I played an E 7 and that was the sharp 9, that's going to be a bluesy sound. But if that G was the fifth of a C major 7 that's a totally different feeling and color, or that notes, the G was the sharp 11 or flat 5, on a D flat chord. That's a really different texture. So I, that's how I write is a I hear a melody and I might just come in one sitting with the chords behind it, but sometimes there might be an area where I'm tweaking it for that right feeling or color that I want in that section.

MR: Does your composing necessarily reflect your mood of the day, of the time that you're sitting down to work on something and you're having a particularly bad spell or a good spell or a Godspell. Do you find that it comes out in your music?

SB: Yeah, I always say, if folks see my live shows, every song, they're more like diary entries to me, to remember places or things or more about that, stuff that was going on when I write it. So you know I might even just write the tune and then when I go to name it I — even if it takes a little time 'til I get to that point I'll think back of the time of the initial inspiration and the title will usually be that. So the titles are more, yes, diary entries, than anything for me.

MR: Nice. I was listening to "Walk Up" — what kind of scales were those, do you recall?

SB: I don't know. They are, it's a minor second and a major second and then it goes up a fourth and up a fourth, and up a fourth, and up a fourth.

MR: That's all right. I'd rather glad that it doesn't have a particular name because I'm sure I wouldn't know what it is.

SB: No. Well, and it starts on — no it's not true, anyway it's just a melody but yes, that's kind of an interesting tune. People like that tune a lot. And I wrote it and then I realized later, much time later, you know part of this celebration for Pat Martino was an amazing event, but anyway you know there's a lot of discussion about, you know, and he's a big influence on me as a guitarist but as a composer. But there was a whole thing about an exercise that he had with minor seven chords that moved down in whole steps. And it hit me, that's where I got it, but that was something I practiced when I was a teenager, you know what I mean? So it's just funny how things stick in your imagination and then they just sort of come out at a different time.

MR: The tune at some point after the walking up melodies, the scales, switched into something else. And I had this feeling like — not to try and get inside your head — but you felt it was time for something else. Like okay here's the bridge. It's something different. How do those things occur to you?

SB: Well I'll tell you what, I think, I'm not, I write a lot of music but you know what? My understanding of harmony again is harmonic analysis and really learning standards and the harmonic analysis through time it just, you internalize that and you just have a natural sense of phrasing and where things should go and song form. Right? And I used to say this to anybody, whether you're going to become a jazz player or not, just if you can get inside those songs they're sort of a blueprint for all contemporary writing. And I think that's what it is, that's where it comes out. So it's more instinctual. I don't really write with an agenda, it just sort of, actually the ones that we play all the time with all my projects are usually the ones that kind of just flow out. So yeah you know it's kind of natural to get to a point and go oh there's a bridge. But I also say maybe it doesn't need a bridge. Sometimes there are songs that don't need a bridge.

MR: At what point do you name them?

SB: When they're finished. When they're finished. And again I'll kind of reflect on what does this remind you of or what happened the initial — when you initially sat down and wrote it.

MR: And another thing that you had mentioned I read, you said transcribing was your bread and butter as far as understanding harmony and improvisation. So you did a lot of that?

SB: Yeah. I did a ton of that, and I wish I had time to do more. But you know I actually didn't even realize 'til actually when I was moving my stuff from my New York apartment to the Boston apartment and I just had files that I hadn't opened for years. And I came across this box of transcription I had done that I had stuff from high school and through my time at Berklee and after. And there were stacks, and there was a ton of Clifford Brown, Dexter Gordon, and Wes — and there was just so — I had forgotten that I'd done all that work. I was like wow, you did do your homework. I think it's essential at some point in your development. And we could say that if you're a rock player or whatever style you play, at some point to dig in to that language, whatever language that you're fascinated in and learn as much as you can from it.

MR: Do you recall when you did all that transcribing if you then — well first of all did you transcribe the chord changes first?

SB: Mmm. That's a great question. I think over time I developed it. At first I think I would find some chart for it. But this was also great, what's great about transcribing is it's the best ear training. So my advice to folks, or if I'm going to do it now, if I'm going to write a chart I usually get the bass first, the melody, and then again it's sort of like the sandwich. What's the flavor of the sandwich. Is it a minor sandwich? Is it a major sandwich? Or is it major sandwich with a — there's something else in there. Oh that's sharp 5 or it's a major sandwich with a flat 5. You know what I mean? But eventually it gets your ear to be able to hear the whole sandwich in time, where you can just sort of do that. So it's a process you know. But I think it's the best way to really learn how to hear harmony.

MR: *DownBeat* and other magazines regularly publish people's transcriptions and some of the authors go to great lengths to point out similarities between bar 3 and bar 17 and really deep analysis of — perhaps I'm misreading — it sounds to me like they're trying to explain what the person who played it was thinking.

SB: Um hum.

MR: And sometimes I wonder, is that assumption correct or were they doing what John Abercrombie described as finger wiggling and this is what came out. In other words there's a certain amount of happy accidents I think, in improvising. Does it need to be explained?

SB: I mean I don't know, I mean we can never say, we can never know what a player is thinking, ever, right? What was going through their mind. But I mean for instance I mean if you see something, for me I mean I think I also use transcription to say, "Oh wow that's a really cool sound on that C 7 chord. What is that?" And then just find the concept behind it you know. Now whether that's what they were thinking — what Joe Pass was thinking that? Probably not. It's just a sound that he's internalized. It's part of his language you know. But in terms of an educational tool to teach myself or to teach a student to say, "Wow, look at that cool diminished, symmetrical diminished line in there." That's cool. What are you going to do with that? I mean going back to this thing about harmonic patterns, when I was a kid the only book that I knew that I had was *Improvising Jazz* by Jerry Coker. And that book, there were two things from that book. And one thing was this thing about licks, which I have a true-fire course, it's called "50 Bebop Licks You Must Know" whatever. But I explain this in the course is that that book really helped me develop a language. Because really you're developing a language like as if you were going to go to France, you'd get a notebook and you'd write things down. How do I say hello? How do I say thanks? And you'd practice them. And then after a while you're just going to say them. So that book was a revelation because it said oh make a diary and try to put that in your vocabulary each week. So then I organized it — oh, things I can play on dominant seventh chords. Things I can play on minor seventh cords. Things I can play on — you know all those things I had these categories. Right? So that was super helpful. And there's like a whole 'nother level of that too that you can expand on. But in the back of the book there's this appendix section of harmonic progressions and they're just numerical. So you can transpose them in any key. That was my secret that I wanted to know. It says: Tunes that start on two dominant. Or progressions that start on two dominant. Progressions that start on the four chord. Progressions that modulate up a major third. And I was like oh, that's what that sound is. Oh it's modulating to the four chord, oh. Because these are quantifiable things. They're not something, you know, there's magic in music, and magic, there's tons of magic. But it's not that. That's science.

MR: Oh I love it. No I just love it because I use that word magic a lot and you just put it in a wonderful context. When you were first on that path of learning/creating your own diary of licks and so forth, were you mostly playing in one key?

SB: I'd write them in the key that I found them, I think, at the time. I'd be interesting if I ever could find that book, wherever it would be. I'd kind of write them in the key that I found them in and then I'd try to work them in to different things. But the thing that's fascinating about that is that you're developing your language, you're developing your

see that something that you could play on a major seven chord you can also play on a minor seven chord and you can also play on a sus chord. So then it was like all these other applications outside of the thing. It was like this is the thing but now I found — as I understood harmony more I could apply it to more things. And then also the other thing that also would just spin me out — for instance, Clifford Brown to me I think is the most impeccable, perfect soloist. Sound, everything. And he could just play a phrase and the idea, the shape of the phrase, if it was a sequence, would fascinate me so much that you could take for instance some kind of sequence that he would play and just start to play through it diatonically and turn them into etudes. So then you're starting to generate your language based on the tradition. And it takes time, all this stuff takes a lot of time and study and, but you know it is fascinating. So you have the actual source, the original source, then the applications of it, and then the stuff that you derive from — hey look at that cool shape. What can I do with that? Or maybe I could put it in a minor key. If it's a major key shape maybe I'll put it in harmonic minor or I'll put it in a symmetrical scale. And then all of a sudden these ideas just blossom into possibilities.

MR: It seems like I've seen articles from guitar players and they talk about shapes. Now that can be a hand shape but it also can be what you're describing as a melodic shape. So which drives which?

SB: Well I tend to think — I mean obviously the guitar is shape oriented. But you know what I always found about — if you, for instance, you take the Charlie Parker "Omni Book" or something — or really any great jazz soloist — and you just squint your eyes you can see the shape of the line. There's peaks and valleys and that. And that's what always fascinated me about horn players and why I always try to sound like a horn or [inaudible] because that sense of using the whole range of your instrument. So I think, I think about the shapes more in that way. In intervals, in actual real music than just guitaristically.

MR: I understand Gene Bertoncini was an important person for you.

SB: Still is.

MR: Yes. I was able to interview him back in 2001 and I wanted to share maybe one or two brief quotes. And I had asked him why jazz, what turned him on. And he said, "I don't quite understand why you are drawn to a particular work or a particular art. I consider it all a gift, the gift of being drawn to the music and wanting to learn that music, a gift of a particular instrument. It's all something we don't really have choices about. I get irritated at people who think they've created their own gift instead of recognizing that it's really something else at play."

SB: Hmm. That's interesting. Yeah.

MR: Yeah what is that something else I wonder, for him? Do you know if he's like a man of

SB: Yeah well I would say he is. I mean I don't know specifically what faith but I remember meeting him and hanging out with him in my early days in New York. And he would always just say, "A career in music? It's an act of faith."

MR: There you go.

SB: And it's true. It is true. You're like well I have a gig next month? Well I have to trust that I will.

MR: You know I felt so naive for a long time thinking about how jazz musicians live and make a living. And I recall — he must have just said it in passing after our interview — about you know, "Yeah well like tomorrow I'm playing a wedding." And I'm thinking Gene Bertoncini plays weddings. And after hearing that from a lot of musicians, well of course I do that, would you rather I wait tables or something? And it was very informative to realize that.

SB: Um hum. Yeah well you know what's a great — on a different art form, stand-up comedy is Joan Rivers. I recommend this movie, "Joan Rivers: A Piece of Work." That first twenty minutes of that movie really shows a working freelance artist. That woman hustled gigs to the day she died. And you know she was like sometimes you're playing at the biggest hall in Vegas or whatever and you've got a long one, sometimes you're doing a bar mitzvah. You do everything with the same integrity. They're not different — and I know that with Gene. If he's playing a wedding or a birthday party, he's playing with the same integrity that he does if he's playing at Carnegie Hall. That's your professional acumen. That's what you bring to everything. You know you don't go ah, I'm going to play for a bunch of loons over here. You would never do that I guess because it is that thing of every time you get a chance to play or perform it is a gift. It really is a gift that you're sharing. Not everybody gets to do that and see what we see.

MR: Um hum. He had a degree in architecture.

SB: Yeah.

MR: And he said that he used to copy plans out of the New York Times Sunday Real Estate section and he liked to plan stuff. "When I play a piece of music I usually arrange it and think of a concept for it."

SB: Um hum. Yeah. He definitely — I think he considers himself an arranger, I mean and an amazing arranger. I mean I met him when I was a teenager and that was a great time. He came to Pittsburgh through the Handyman, he was one of the great guitarists and stuff. But he had the thing about the Segovia scales, which are really — they move up on each string. So there's kind of two ways you could play — you could play what we call in hand position and a grip, or you could play up each string. And so seeing him present that I was at that time I had the time to do that as a teenager, I would practice — I learned all

that was so influential in how I saw the guitar, which I credit to that moment of crossing paths with him. And then fast forward when I moved to New York and I hung out with him and took some lessons. And Gene was always so welcoming of me anytime I came by to sit in with him and introduce me to people. He was just so generous. But anyway, that's what I studied with him was arranging standards. And I learned so much, I mean stuff that I share with all my students and stuff that I'm still working on all the time.

MR: Um hum. There's two topics that are often subjects of scholarly writings. One is jazz and race, and the other one that I'd like to bring up is women in jazz. And I found this in my stuff here — this is an issue of *DownBeat* December 1964. And I was looking through it and the only mention of a woman musician was a letter writer to the editor saying, "Nancy Wilson is beautiful." Apparently they did have her on a previous cover. And he wrote in to say that that's the best cover ever. So that was 1964. Now if we fast forward to — this is the latest issue of *DownBeat*, the 2023 Critics' Poll. And I'm not sure how I got into this but I counted how many categories in the Critics' Poll and if you include what they call "rising stars" there's like 60 categories and 25 of them the number one person is a woman.

SB: Wow that's great.

MR: Yeah. And have you ever had issues in the business?

SB: Well if we were to say the business is a microcosm of the world — you know — and we're in an interesting time just dissecting gender, right? Like what does it really mean? So to me it doesn't really mean anything in terms of picking up the guitar and playing it every day. Having two X chromosomes really doesn't mean anything. I mean it's not, you know, the physicality of the instrument — there's nothing that would, you know, that I would need massive amounts of testosterone to be able to play it physically. So anyway I never concentrated on it, and I've had plenty of opportunities where people wanted to push that aspect of my career and I would have to say only since I became the assistant chair at Berklee College of Music did it really dawn on me that I could be in a place of influence. But up until then actually I've made it not really a part of how I market my music. You know people will say, "You're the best female guitarist." I'm like there's only one list. Either you can play or you can't play. And if I'm not on that list, that's the only list I'm shooting for. That's the only list I ever wanted to be on. So that's how I think about it.

MR: Good point. I remember Marian McPartland saying a similar thing — like with her wonderful accent you know, pointing out that oh she's the finest woman jazz pianist.

SB: Right, right, right, right, right. Yeah I mean in this art form hopefully it is about the music. We want it to be about the music. And I always say if you blindfold somebody —

we're listening to music? It's the best male guitarist, it's the best female. I mean come on. Like life is complicated enough. Let's just listen and play the music. Either you can play or you can't play. That's what it comes down to for me.

MR: Another quote from Sheryl. I recently interviewed a number of musicians who mostly made their life in the studios, some of them going way back and a lot of them point out that that part of the business has changed so much and a lot of the studio work is disappearing because it can be replaced. And I wonder if you — I hadn't even thought about this until this morning actually, that the guitar I think is the hardest instrument to replace electronically or synthesizer-wise. There's something about it and maybe it's more immune to the technology than other instruments that can be easily re-created now.

SB: That might be true. I mean I think there's some great scoring of guitar in some of the TV shows that — it's all guitar-generated stuff and different sounds, and definitely, because you know if you're talking about film scoring you could have a scene in a honky tonk, you could have a scene in a jazz club, you could have — you know I mean there are so many places, an acoustic guitar, could be flamencos kind of sound. Yeah, it's not reproducible in an electronic way that's convincing.

MR: Yeah. There's something about the strumming and it's just hard to reproduce that. If I went to a jazz club in New York that you were playing at would I see a lot of foot pedals or things to stomp on?

SB: It depends. If you saw me with Anat Cohen yes, because I have to do my big flame-thrower solo at the end. Yeah I mean I use certain things because sometimes I have some tunes that might have a certain vibe. Most of the time I go for a clean sound but you know I always like to have some options.

MR: Um hum. And do your students ask you about that part of the guitar world? About the technology available? Actually I'm going to re-phrase that question to include do you encourage them to learn Finale and all the technology that is out there to record at home etcetera?

SB: Yeah. Well definitely. I mean Berklee has all that stuff, and for sure. I mean I think the thing about home recording, and you know the way people are scoring now is even just transferring files and people record it at home you know. So you might play on a film score and you just send the files via Dropbox and you've never even met the producer person. So I mean this is a big thing. And definitely for guitar players, it is a thing to be able to have the right sound for the gig. You know? But I learn a lot from them because they're always up on, you know, what the latest gear is so I'm always trading stuff with them too.

MR: How do you get — speaking of gigs — if you want to play at Smoke's or any number of

York City and the chance of getting into some of the better clubs must be very competitive.

SB: Well you know I mean the thing about, I mean it doesn't have to be jazz, but you're only as good as your last gig. It's word of mouth. Your career is word of mouth. You're on a gig, someone hears you and they love the way you play. They love the way you sound. They love your attitude. And then you get the calls. And then you're a sideperson or you start to develop something. And that's really how it goes. I mean you know this is a kind of a funny age where with some of the younger kids they're coming up in this idea that they have an Instagram or a TikTok post and they can play something for 20 seconds. Like — well how do you sound on a gig? Can you play on it? Do you know tunes? All those things count. So I think that's really how you build your career is through what you're doing right now.

MR: Do you have any like things that — I'll use the word "aggravate you" on gigs?

SB: Yes. Everyone does.

MR: I should probably narrow that a little bit, yes I'm aggravated by interviewers who ask these really broad questions.

SB: Like you're asking a New Yorker, what aggravates you?

MR: "Let me talk about the subway." I guess I'm thinking of you know getting on a gig, especially if it's yours — what would happen on the bandstand that would aggravate you enough to not call a person again?

SB: Oh. Comping. If I don't like the way they comp and they could be a great soloist, I'll call you later. Comping is the number one thing.

MR: What kind of comping don't you like to play over?

SB: If it's too — well you know comping is so deep because it's in the moment and it depends on what's happening with the music. And so listening — it's kind of knowing when to jump in and when to jump out. And so you know most people have a good groove. Sometimes maybe someone's too busy. Maybe — I don't like people that always have to quote or play back what I play and quote it back to me. That's a little — anyway — so it's just got to feel good. You know?

MR: I work with a drummer who's the only person I ever knew who uses silence as one of his sounds. Like laying out at the beginning of a tune or even in the middle of a tune, that it sounds so interesting when they come back in.

SB: Totally.

MR: And I'm so surprised that it's not in people's sort of library of things to do.

SB: Me too. You know one time when I was a kid, and I'm sure it's cause I was just mindlessly clomping away, but my teacher said — this was in my first ensemble in

Pittsburgh as a kid — he's staring at me, he goes, "You know what Monk said?" I said, "What, teacher." And he said, "The hippest thing I ever did was lay out."

MR: I think Chick Corea said that too. He said if you can't hear it then don't play or something like that. I mean silence is — I think of it as a sound of its own I guess.

SB: That's great. I love that. That's great.

MR: Do you have coming next projects in mind?

SB: Yeah. Well I just put this record out and I did it in a different way. It's on YouTube so I can tell you've been checking it out. It's free on YouTube and there's a whole series with it. It's still dropping over the summer. It'll still be there. It's also on vinyl so I thought let's do this, which is doing well, it's actually selling really well. And digital downloads through me. So I said hey I want to take back control of this. There's one tune, "Block Up" is streaming so you can get that on iTunes and stuff. So this is sort of an experiment. It's been interesting. So that's sort of ongoing. I just — I have something new coming out, I just started working with Jerry Bergonzi which is incredible. I mean wow what a moment to work with him. So we have something coming out with him on a record he has coming out on Savant I think this fall. Harvie S., Phil Grenadier and Luther Gray. And then we recorded something very recently, I don't know when that will come out, probably later next year. And then a project — we just played at Small's — it's called "Taurus Power" and it's with my friend Marian McSweeney, longtime buddy and collaborator, a great bass player, great composer. So it's the two of us with Jerry Bergonzi as our special guest. Mike Fahn on valve trombone and Austin McMahon on drums. So we're mixing that right now so we're looking at maybe releasing that maybe next spring either on vinyl or whatever. But things are coming up, are Jerry Bergonzi's release in the fall. So I'm very excited — I mean to me he's the top of the mountain in terms of musicianship and God, just virtuosity, but also generosity and kindness as an artist, composer, educator. He's just — it's been an amazing experience to meet him and become part of his musical family.

MR: It's wonderful when you find — how many saxophone players are there out there — and you find someone who in particular plays your music in ways that you hadn't even imagined.

SB: Yeah, yes. Well he's — I mean he's an amazing composer. He's so prolific and he's so open just I mean as a person. But he brings that to the music. He's a great mentor and influence in my life right now.

MR: Well you've had a number of those which is a terrific thing over the years.

SB: Yeah, and also we have something with Anat Cohen — we'll be touring in early 2024 — God 2024 — yeah we'll have a West Coast tour. And I hope that we'll have some new

music for the tentet. That is a really fun, super fun project. So anyway that'll, there'll be more chapters of that band too.

MR: Is it hard to get particular individuals together for a tour like that? Everybody's got to sort of clear their calendar and say you have to tell your Berklee folks well I'm going to be engaged elsewhere —

SB: Yeah, well they usually book these things pretty far in advance. Every once in a while we'll have to have a sub — we always say somebody's great, but yeah, it can be difficult.

MR: Okay. Well this has been a marvelous conversation. I want to thank you for your time.

SB: Sure thank you, it was super fun. Great questions.

MR: And good luck with your projects. I left out one question I had about your composing and that is do you ever plagiarize yourself?

SB: Ha! I think everybody does. Yeah. I mean when you hear anybody and you listen to a bunch of their music in a row you hear techniques and — what's the word — tendencies. Yeah. Everybody has their tendencies. But I think that's why you should write more because the more you write it hones that, your voice as a composer. I think it's good.

MR: Terrific. Thanks for your time, Sheryl.

SB: Yeah thank you. I look forward to checking this out when it's done and we'll share it around. It was great. Thank you so much.